



ADVENTURES IN SOUTHWEST FLORIDA

SWFL Birding Hotspots

A free field guide to thirteen
Southwest Florida birding stops

www.adventureswflorida.com

How to use this guide

The Great Florida Birding and Wildlife Trail is a statewide network of places picked for birds and other wildlife. Brown road signs mark many of the stops. This booklet is the Southwest Florida slice: thirteen places in Lee, Collier, and Charlotte counties worth planning a morning around, plus a shorter list of other trail sites nearby. Harns Marsh is the one that is not a signed trail stop. It is here because it is where people go for snail kites.

It is an independent guide from Adventures in Southwest Florida, not an official publication of the Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission. Fees, hours, closures, and hunt dates change. Confirm the stop before you go. The full statewide map lives at floridabirdingtrail.com.

The thirteen stops

01	J. N. "Ding" Darling National Wildlife Refuge	Lee · Sanibel
02	San Carlos Bay: Bunche Beach Preserve	Lee · Fort Myers
03	Six Mile Cypress Slough Preserve	Lee · Fort Myers
04	Lakes Regional Park	Lee · Fort Myers
05	Lovers Key State Park	Lee · Fort Myers Beach
06	Hickey's Creek Mitigation Park	Lee · Alva
07	Harns Marsh	Lee · Lehigh Acres
08	Corkscrew Swamp Sanctuary	Collier · Naples
09	CREW Marsh Trails	Collier · Immokalee
10	Collier-Seminole State Park	Collier · Naples
11	Fakahatchee Strand: Big Cypress Bend Boardwalk	Collier · East of Naples
12	Charlotte Harbor Environmental Center	Charlotte · Punta Gorda
13	Babcock/Webb Wildlife Management Area	Charlotte · Punta Gorda

The paintings in this guide are original illustrations, made for this booklet. They are not photographs of the sites. Use them to picture the habitat. Use the directions to get there.

Season, tide, and manners

October through April is the easy season. The heat breaks, wintering ducks and shorebirds arrive, warblers filter through the hammocks, and American white pelicans show up on the larger flats. March through May is migration, and swallow-tailed kites return for the summer. June through September is breeding season, afternoon storms, and serious bugs. Go early, carry water, and give nesting terns and skimmers a wide berth.

On the coast, tide matters more than the clock. Bunche Beach, Ding Darling, and the Charlotte Harbor flats are different places at low tide than they are at high tide. A free tide chart for Fort Myers or Punta Gorda is part of the kit.

Stay outside posted habitat

Critical Wildlife Areas, including Little Estero Island, are closed to entry. Watch from the public beach or a marked trail. If birds flush, you are too close. Back up and let them settle.

Leave the nesting birds alone

Skip call playback at crowded sites and during nesting season. It pulls birds off nests and off the business of feeding.

Alligators are part of the walk

They use nearly every freshwater site in this guide. Keep dogs leashed and children back from the edge. Do not feed anything.

Hunting country is still public

Babcock/Webb is a wildlife management area with scheduled hunts. Read the current brochure, pay the daily-use fee unless you are exempt, and wear blaze orange on hunt days.

Pack

Binoculars, a sun hat, more water than you think, insect repellent, closed shoes for flatwoods, and shoes you can rinse after the beach. Download the refuge or park page before you lose signal. A folding chair is overkill everywhere except the Ding Darling pullouts, where it is a fine idea.

Before you leave the house

Check the tide if the stop is on the Gulf or the harbor. Check the refuge or park page for a closure. If the plan includes Babcock/Webb, check the hunt calendar and the daily-use fee. Then go early. Southwest Florida gives up its best birds before the heat does.

J. N. "Ding" Darling National Wildlife Refuge



WHERE 1 Wildlife Drive, Sanibel, FL 33957

WHEN Daylight hours. Wildlife Drive is often closed one day a week. Check the refuge calendar.

COST A fee applies to Wildlife Drive. Bailey Tract is a free walk.

This is the Southwest Florida picture people already have in their heads: spoonbills and egrets feeding on a falling tide, mangroves on the far side of the flat, and a one-way drive that makes you slow down. Go when the water is dropping or already low. That is when reddish egrets work the shallows and yellow-crowned night-herons stand in the mangrove edge. Winter adds American white pelicans.

Use the pullouts and shut the engine off when you stop. Bailey Tract, off Tarpon Bay Road, is the walking version of the refuge when the drive is closed or the island is crowded.

Field note: If you have to choose, take the falling tide over the prettier sunrise.

WATCH Roseate Spoonbill, Reddish Egret, Yellow-crowned Night-Heron, Osprey, American White Pelican in winter

San Carlos Bay: Bunche Beach Preserve



WHERE 18201 John Morris Road, Fort Myers, FL 33908
WHEN Sunrise to sunset. Plan the visit around low tide.
COST Parking is \$2 per hour. A Lee County annual parking pass is accepted.

A protected beach and mangrove shore with some of the best shorebirding in Lee County. Walk either direction from the parking area and glass both the sand and the mangrove line. Willets probe the tide line year-round. Plovers gather through the cooler months: Wilson's, piping, black-bellied, and semipalmated. At low tide, reddish egrets and roseate spoonbills feed the flats. Least terns hunt overhead, and a bald eagle is a fair bet on a long enough scan.

Early morning and late evening are also when birds move between this beach and roosts on the salt flats inland. Give resting flocks room. If they stand up and shift, you are already too close.

Field note: Bring a tide chart. High tide here is mostly a pretty, empty beach.

WATCH Willet, Wilson's Plover, Piping Plover, Black-bellied Plover, Semipalmated Plover, Reddish Egret, Roseate Spoonbill, Least Tern

Six Mile Cypress Slough Preserve



WHERE 7751 Penzance Boulevard, Fort Myers, FL 33966

WHEN Boardwalk from dawn to dusk. The interpretive center is typically closed Monday.

COST A parking fee may apply.

A boardwalk loop through a cypress slough that still cuts through suburban Fort Myers. It is short enough for a first morning in town and good enough to walk again. Limpkins call from the cypress knees, anhingas dry on snags, and wood storks drop in when the water level suits them. Barred owls and red-shouldered hawks use the bigger timber. Wood ducks keep to the darker creeks, and migrating warblers pass through the cypress in spring and fall.

The slough is dark, wet, and full even when the parking lot is busy. Stay on the boardwalk. A river otter is a lucky sight, not one to count on.

Field note: Weekday morning. Midday in summer belongs to the mosquitoes.

WATCH Limpkin, Wood Stork, Wood Duck, Anhinga, Barred Owl, migrating warblers

Lakes Regional Park



WHERE 7330 Gladiolus Drive, Fort Myers, FL 33908
WHEN Park hours. Morning is cooler and the birds are more active.
COST A parking fee may apply.

The easy day. Paved paths circle freshwater lakes under cypress, so this works with a stroller, a bad knee, or a single free hour. Great blue herons, tricolored herons, and great egrets are reliable. Black-bellied whistling-ducks and mottled ducks use the lakes, and winter brings a wider mix of ducks. Check the lily edges for a purple gallinule.

It will not feel wild in the way Ding Darling does. It will produce birds, shade, and a loop you can finish. Pair it with Bunche Beach: fresh water in the morning, the Gulf when the tide is out.

Field note: Walk the quieter lake edges first, before the picnic areas wake up.

WATCH Great Blue Heron, Tricolored Heron, Black-bellied Whistling-Duck, Mottled Duck, Anhinga, Purple Gallinule

Lovers Key State Park



WHERE 8700 Estero Boulevard, Fort Myers Beach, FL 33931

WHEN Typically 8 a.m. to sunset. Confirm state park hours.

COST Florida State Parks entrance fee.

A barrier-island beach with a lagoon behind it. Black skimmers and terns use the sand. The backwaters hold herons, egrets, and ibises. A tram runs to the beach when it is operating. You can also walk or bike out.

Just south of the park, Little Estero Island is a Critical Wildlife Area. Watch skimmers and shorebirds from the public beach. Do not cross ropes or signs into posted habitat, especially while birds are nesting. A resting flock is not an invitation to walk closer.

Field note: Stay on the public sand and let the long lens do the walking.

WATCH Black Skimmer, Sandwich Tern, Wilson's Plover, waders in the lagoon

Hickey's Creek Mitigation Park



WHERE 17980 Palm Beach Boulevard, Alva, FL 33920

WHEN Daily, 7 a.m. to 6 p.m.

COST Parking is \$1 per hour or \$5 per day. A Lee County annual pass is accepted.

This is the local place to look for Florida scrub-jays. The Palmetto Pines Trail crosses the low oak scrub they need. The North Marsh Trail looks over a wetland used by waders and swallows. The creek trail is the migration walk: warblers move through the hardwoods along this tributary of the Caloosahatchee, and northern waterthrush is a fair find in season.

Gopher tortoises use the same sandy ground. The kayak put-in is about half a mile from the parking lot. Carry a boat only if you mean to. The creek is also part of the Great Calusa Blueway.

Field note: If the pines are quiet, keep walking the scrub. That is where the jays are.

WATCH Florida Scrub-Jay, Eastern Towhee, Pine Warbler, gopher tortoise

Harns Marsh



- WHERE** End of 38th Street West, Lehigh Acres. From Lee Boulevard, go north on Sunshine Boulevard, left on Olive Avenue North, then left on 38th Street West.
- WHEN** Dawn to dusk, unless posted. It can close for high water or maintenance.
- COST** No entrance fee. There are no facilities. Leave vehicles outside the gate.

This is the drive to Lehigh Acres. Apple snails in the marsh support snail kites, and this is one of the reliable places to look for them outside the Everglades. Limpkins work the same snails. Black-bellied whistling-ducks loaf on the open water, and herons and egrets line the edges.

Harns Marsh is not a signed stop on the Great Florida Birding and Wildlife Trail, and it is not a park. The Lehigh Acres water district opens it for walking. Stay on the walkway. Do not count on a restroom, and pack out what you bring.

Field note: Look across the open water before you start walking. Snail kites hunt out over the marsh, often farther away than they first appear.

- WATCH** Snail Kite, Limpkin, Black-bellied Whistling-Duck, herons and egrets

Corkscrew Swamp Sanctuary



WHERE 375 Sanctuary Road West, Naples, FL 34120

WHEN Daytime hours set by Audubon. Check corkscrew.audubon.org before you go.

COST Admission fee.

The old-growth cypress walk in this part of Florida. A boardwalk a little over two miles round trip passes through a swamp that still looks like itself: huge bald cypress, ferns, and dark water. Wood storks are the headliner. The sanctuary was protected around their nesting, and they are here when the water is right for feeding young.

Walk slowly. Barred owls sit closer to the trail than people expect, and pileated woodpeckers work the larger trunks. In winter, check near the visitor center for painted buntings before you commit to the full loop.

Field note: Be there when the gate opens. The swamp is quieter, and the light is still in the trees.

WATCH Wood Stork, Barred Owl, Pileated Woodpecker, Painted Bunting in winter near the visitor center

CREW Marsh Trails



WHERE 4600 Corkscrew Road (CR 850), Immokalee, FL 34142

WHEN One hour before sunrise until one hour after sunset.

COST Free. Donations keep the trails open.

Free, large, and a little wild. Marked loops, about five and a half miles if you walk them all, cross pine flatwoods, oak hammocks, popash slough, and the edge of a sawgrass marsh thousands of acres wide. Boardwalks keep the wet sections walkable. An observation tower looks out over the marsh.

Swallow-tailed kites nest in this country in spring and summer. From the tower, watch for them, for bald eagles, and now and then a snail kite. There is a portable toilet at the trailhead and no trash service. Pack out everything. Bring plenty of water.

Field note: From I-75 exit 123, go east on Corkscrew Road. You pass the Cypress Dome Trails first. The marsh trailhead is farther east, on the right.

WATCH Swallow-tailed Kite in spring and summer, Red-shouldered Hawk, woodpeckers, waders from the tower. Snail Kite is possible over the marsh.

Collier-Seminole State Park



WHERE 20200 Tamiami Trail East, Naples, FL 34114
WHEN Typically 8 a.m. to sunset. Confirm state park hours.
COST Florida State Parks entrance fee.

This is where temperate pine country runs into the subtropics. A short nature trail passes through a royal palm hammock to a marsh overlook where white ibises and spoonbills gather. A longer hike and an unpaved bike path reach flatwoods and scrub. In the warm months, look up. Swallow-tailed kites course over this park.

If the uplands are quiet, the mangrove canoe trail is where the birding is. Wild turkeys use the pines, and the hammock can hold a good warbler morning in migration. Bring water. The trail does not get kinder at noon.

Field note: Walk the palm hammock first, then decide whether the day wants a paddle.

WATCH White Ibis, Swallow-tailed Kite in the warm months, Pileated Woodpecker, Wild Turkey

Fakahatchee Strand: Big Cypress Bend Boardwalk



WHERE 27020 Tamiami Trail East, Naples, FL 34114

WHEN 8 a.m. to sunset.

COST A small vehicle fee, recently about \$3. Pay at the station and confirm the current rate.

The easy door into the Fakahatchee Strand, a cypress and royal palm swamp. Hurricane Ian closed the old boardwalk in 2022. It was rebuilt in stages and fully reopened in late 2025, with a walk of about 2.3 miles round trip through old trees and out to a lake. The path is mostly flat. Green herons, waders, and barred owls are the likely birds. Air plants and the size of the cypress are the rest of the reason to go.

The strand is much larger than this walk. The main preserve entrance is in Copeland, and the two areas are not connected by a road inside the park. Pick one for the day.

Field note: About seven miles west of State Road 29 on U.S. 41. There is one entrance to the boardwalk.

WATCH Green Heron, Great Egret, Barred Owl, Pileated Woodpecker

Charlotte Harbor Environmental Center



WHERE 10941 Burnt Store Road, Punta Gorda, FL 33955

WHEN Trails down to dusk through the walk-in gate. The office is typically open on weekdays.

COST Trails are free.

CHEC sits on the edge of the Charlotte Harbor preserve along Burnt Store Road. Linked trails leave from the center and run through pine flatwoods toward Alligator Creek. Red-headed woodpeckers, pine warblers, and eastern towhees work the uplands. The creek and harbor edges are for herons, ibises, and, at low tide, shorebirds.

Guided hikes are often offered in season, including the occasional night walk. You do not need a program to bird here. The walk-through gate by the kiosk opens onto the trails even when the building is closed.

Field note: Do not turn around at the first pine stand. The harbor end of the walk is the payoff.

WATCH Red-headed Woodpecker, Pine Warbler, Eastern Towhee, White Ibis toward the creek

Babcock/Webb Wildlife Management Area



WHERE	Tucker Grade entrance, 29200 Tucker Grade, Punta Gorda, FL 33955
WHEN	About 1.5 hours before sunrise until 1.5 hours after sunset, unless a gate is closed.
COST	Daily-use permit: \$3 per person or \$6 per vehicle, unless you have a management area permit or a listed exemption.

A vast wildlife management area, and one of the best places in the region for red-cockaded woodpeckers. Drive the named roads slowly. Watch mature pines for the white resin wells the birds keep around their cavities. The same open woods hold sandhill cranes, northern bobwhite, wild turkeys, Bachman's sparrows, and brown-headed nuthatches. In winter, American bitterns and sedge wrens use the wetter grass.

This is also a hunting area. On hunt days, wear blaze orange and skip the first hour of daylight. Florida residents under 16 or over 65 are among the people who may be exempt from the daily-use fee. Read the current FWC brochure before you count on that.

Field note: Check the hunt calendar at myfwc.com before you pick a morning.

WATCH	Red-cockaded Woodpecker, Sandhill Crane, Brown-headed Nuthatch, Bachman's Sparrow, Wild Turkey
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Other sites worth knowing

These are also on the Great Florida Birding and Wildlife Trail. They are real mornings, just not the twelve this booklet walks you through. Look up the current page on floridabirdingtrail.com before you aim the car at one.

Lee County

Caloosahatchee Regional Park

River hammock in Alva, across the water from Hickey's Creek.

Matanzas Pass Preserve

A mangrove boardwalk on Fort Myers Beach.

Estero Bay Preserve State Park

Estuary trails, including access from the Winkler and Estero River areas.

Cayo Costa State Park

A boat-in barrier island. Plan the landing, not a quick stop.

Bowditch Point Park

The north end of Fort Myers Beach, where the inlet concentrates birds.

Lighthouse Beach Park

Sanibel's lighthouse shore. Good after, or instead of, a crowded Wildlife Drive.

Blind Pass Beach Park

The cut between Sanibel and Captiva. Shorebirds use the pass.

Collier County

Delnor-Wiggins Pass State Park

Beach and inlet at the north end of Naples.

Conservancy of Southwest Florida

Boardwalks and a nature center in Naples. Admission applies.

Rookery Bay Reserve

Learning center and trails on the edge of a large estuary.

Tigertail Beach

Marco Island lagoon and beach. Another low-tide shorebird stop.

Eagle Lakes Community Park

An easy urban lake circuit in Naples.

Picayune Strand: Sabal Palm Trail

A hiking trail in the state forest south of I-75.

Big Cypress National Preserve

Scenic drives and roadside stops. Carry water and a full tank.

Charlotte County

Charlotte Flatwoods Environmental Park

Wet prairie and pine flatwoods on the east side of the county.

Old Datsun Trail

A short flatwoods walk in Charlotte Harbor Preserve that ends at the harbor. Low tide.

North Cape Flats Trail

Another mile of flatwoods to mudflats. Oystercatchers and plovers when the tide is out.

Cedar Point Environmental Park

Coastal scrub and harbor views near Englewood.

Pick the habitat, not the postcard

The famous tide

Ding Darling on a falling tide. Add Lighthouse Beach or Blind Pass if the drive is closed, or if you want a second stop on the island.

Snail kites

Harns Marsh in Lehigh Acres. Look over the open water before you walk. Snail kites hunt over the marsh, and black-bellied whistling-ducks loaf on it.

Shorebirds without the causeway

Bunche Beach at low tide. Lakes Park first if you want fresh water and an easy start.

A swamp walk

Corkscrew if you want old cypress and do not mind a fee. Six Mile Cypress if you are already in Fort Myers. Big Cypress Bend if you are driving toward the Everglades.

Scrub and pine

Hickey's Creek at opening for Florida scrub-jays. Babcock/Webb the same day only if you have checked the hunt calendar and sorted the daily-use permit.

Naples, slowly

Collier-Seminole in the morning, Delnor-Wiggins or Tigertail when the tide suits the beach.

Birds by season

October to April

Wintering shorebirds and ducks, American white pelicans, warblers in the hammocks, painted buntings, the most comfortable walking weather of the year.

March to May

Northbound migrants, the return of swallow-tailed kites, the last of the winter ducks. Mornings on a hammock trail can change by the hour.

May to September

Nesting terns, skimmers, and waders. Kites all summer. Storms after lunch. Fewer people, more heat, and posted nesting areas you leave alone.

Use outsideplan.com to help plan the outing. It is built for sorting the stop, the timing, and what to bring before you leave.

Take it with you

This guide is free. Download it, print it, and pass it to someone who is about to spend a morning badly by going to the beach at high tide. Please do not sell it or republish it as your own.

Adventures in Southwest Florida writes and photographs the wildlife of this coast. Twelve of these stops are on the Great Florida Birding and Wildlife Trail. Harns Marsh is included because it is the place to look for snail kites. The words and the paintings are ours. For closures, fees, and the rest of the statewide trail, use the official site.

Adventures in Southwest Florida

www.adventuresswflorida.com

Outside Plan

outsideplan.com

Great Florida Birding and Wildlife Trail

floridabirdingtrail.com

Florida Fish and Wildlife Conservation Commission

myfwc.com

Corkscrew Swamp Sanctuary

corkscrew.audubon.org

Ding Darling National Wildlife Refuge

fws.gov/refuge/jn-ding-darling

Confirm hours, fees, and closures before you go. The birds will still be the best part.

Guide prepared in 2026. Trail site facts were checked against park and trail pages then. A gate, a fee, or a hunt calendar may have changed since.